front matter

preface

ASP.NET has a long history; Microsoft released the first version in 2002 as part of the original .NET Framework 1.0. Since then, it's been through multiple iterations, each version bringing added features and extensibility. Each iteration, however, was built on the same underlying framework provided by System.Web.dll. This library is part of the .NET Framework, so it comes preinstalled in all versions of Windows.

This brings mixed blessings. On one hand, the ASP.NET 4.X framework today is a reliable, battle-tested platform for building modern applications on Windows. On the other hand, it is limited by this reliance; changes to the underlying System.Web.dll are far-reaching and consequently slow to roll out, and it fundamentally excludes the many developers who are building and deploying to Linux or macOS.

When I began looking into ASP.NET Core, I was one of those developers. A Windows user at heart, I was issued a Mac by my employer, so I was stuck working in a virtual machine all day. ASP.NET Core promised to change all that, allowing me to develop natively on both my Windows machine and my Mac.

I was relatively late to the party in many respects, taking an active interest only just before the RC2 release of ASP.NET Core. By this point there had already been eight (!) beta releases, many of which contained significant breaking changes. By not diving in fully until RC2, I was spared the pain of dodgy tooling and changing APIs.